



ASTRONOMER

JOB DESCRIPTION

Astronomers are scientists who study the Universe. They rely on ground- or space-based telescopes, spacecraft, and other advanced instruments to make their observations. Using mathematical techniques to interpret data, they investigate the properties and behavior of planets, stars, and galaxies, and then propose and test theories about the nature and makeup of the Universe.



SALARY

Graduate student ★★★★★

Astronomy professor ★★★★★★

INDUSTRY PROFILE

Academic profession with few employment opportunities • Entry to research posts is competitive • Jobs found in government departments, laboratories, and observatories

AT A GLANCE



YOUR INTERESTS Astronomy • Mathematics • Physics • Chemistry • Geology • Engineering • Information Technology (IT) • Exploration



ENTRY QUALIFICATIONS Entrants to this profession usually hold an advanced degree in astronomy, space science, astrophysics, or geophysics.



LIFESTYLE Studying the sky and collecting data can involve long, irregular hours. Weekend and evening work is a crucial part of the job.



LOCATION Astronomers work mainly in space laboratories, observatories, and research departments. They may travel for meetings and conferences.



THE REALITIES This is a highly demanding, theoretical field. Entry is competitive, and many graduates are not able to find work as astronomers.

CAREER PATHS

Because astronomy is a highly academic field, aspiring astronomers need a degree in physics or astronomy and usually a PhD to progress. Most professional astronomers carry out research and hold teaching posts at universities, but some move into related fields, such as instrument engineering, computer programming, or space science, where they provide support for space missions.

GRADUATE If you have an astronomy degree, you can apply for support roles in planetariums, research laboratories, and science museums. You can also gain relevant work experience before moving to graduate study.



POSTGRADUATE You will require the highest level of academic qualifications to progress in this field; a master's or PhD in astronomy will improve your prospects.

